

'GLP-1 DRUGS MAY BE THE BREAKTHROUGH OF THIS CENTURY'

Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, Executive Chairperson of Biocon, says India—home to one of the world's largest diabetic populations—has immense potential for GLP-1 prescriptions

India faces a dual epidemic of diabetes and obesity. Over 77 million people are living with diabetes in India, while there is a rising prevalence of obesity. Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, Executive Chairperson of Biocon, in an exclusive interaction with *BT*, discusses innovation in diabetes management, the company's leadership in biosimilar insulins and GLP-1 therapies, and envisions India's large diabetic population driving opportunities for GLP-1 treatments. Edited excerpts:

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What are the new trends in diabetes and obesity that are likely to make a difference in the years ahead?

If you look at diabetes—or diabetes, as I now call it—it is taking on a completely new dimension. Even in biosimilars, we are a very differentiated company because we are the only ones developing biosimilar insulins. Today, we are the third-largest insulin

producer in the world, after Novo Nordisk and Eli Lilly.

I remember, about six or seven years ago, telling my team, 'Let's aspire to have one in five insulin users in the world using Biocon insulin.' We have already surpassed that goal. Now, I need to revisit that aspiration and aim for one in two. If we achieve that, we will be the largest insulin company in the world.

We are also the only company globally with a combination of insulins and GLP-1s. We have already developed GLP-1 peptides and received the world's first approval for a GLP-1 peptide—liraglutide—from the UK. We are progressing well with other GLP-1 approvals, including semaglutide, which will go off-patent in emerging markets and Canada by 2026. This opens up significant opportunities.

But, the competition will be fierce. Scale will be a key factor, and it's not just about manu-



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facturing the peptides; it's also about creating device capabilities that can convert these innovations into market-ready products.

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What should India focus on?

India must prioritise advancements in drug delivery technologies. There is immense potential in subcutaneous formulations for cancer drugs that are currently infused. Similarly, we need to explore nanoparticle-based delivery systems, depot technologies for sustained release, and extended-release tablets. These innovations, where patients don't need to take a pill or injection daily, represent a major area requiring deeper research.

For diabetics, the combination of insulin and GLP-1s has been transformative. GLP-1s are now seen as a panacea for metabolic diseases, like diabetes, obesity, cardiac ailments, and even

Alzheimer's. Trials are showing remarkable results, suggesting that these drugs may well be the breakthrough of this century.

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What is the market opportunity for GLP-1s in India?

Globally, the GLP-1 market exceeds \$150 billion. While this figure will shrink significantly with the onset of generics, the opportunity remains vast. India, home to one of the world's largest diabetic populations, has immense potential for GLP-1 prescriptions.

Currently, India's insulin business is worth half a billion dollars, and in many global markets, these figures are in the billions. Using similar projections, the GLP-1 market in India could easily reach multi-billion-pound levels. As this therapeutic class evolves, the possibilities for addressing diabetes and related metabolic diseases are truly transformative.